

BREATHLESS COMBAT

AIR COMBAT IN WORLD WAR II monoplane fighters was conducted at a speed that pushed a pilot's reaction times to the limits. In 1941, future author Roald Dahl was flying with the RAF in Greece when the Luftwaffe arrived in strength:

"Over Athens on that morning, I can remember seeing our tight little formation of Hurricanes all peeling away and disappearing among the swarms of enemy aircraft. They came from above and they came from behind and they made frontal attacks from dead ahead, and I threw my Hurricane around as best I could and whenever a Hun came into my sights, I pressed the button. It was truly the most breathless and in a way the most exhilarating time I have ever had in my life. I caught glimpses of planes with black smoke pouring from their engines. I saw the bright red flashes coming from the wings of the Messerschmitts as they fired their guns, and once I saw a man whose Hurricane was in flames climb calmly out onto a wing and jump off..."

Landing at his airfield after surviving this experience, Dahl found he was perspiring so heavily the sweat was dripping to the ground, and his hand was shaking so much he couldn't light a cigarette.

HURRICANE FORCE

Designed by Sydney Camm, the Hawker Hurricane was the RAF's first monoplane fighter and the mainstay of Fighter Command in the Battle of Britain. Although slower than a Messerschmitt, it was tighter in the turn, an advantage in a dogfight.



"Wherever I looked I saw an endless blur of enemy fighters whizzing toward me from every side..."

ROALD DAHL
RAF PILOT AND WRITER

early examples of this novel military tactic was the taking of the apparently formidable Belgian frontier fortress of Eben Emael on May 10, 1940. Forty-one Ju 52s, each towing a glider with a contingent of troops on board, flew over German territory toward the Belgian border under cover of darkness, guided by beacons spaced out on the ground below. The gliders were released at very first light and most landed on top of the fortress or alongside nearby strongpoints. Taken completely

by surprise, Eben Emael's garrison of over 1,000 soldiers soon meekly surrendered.

The most spectacular German airborne assault was the invasion of the Mediterranean island of Crete in May 1941 – the first exclusively airborne invasion in history. Some 5,000 paratroopers were dropped on the island, occupied by almost 30,000 British and Commonwealth troops. They seized and held the airfield at Maleme, where Luftwaffe

transport aircraft were then able to land with large-scale reinforcements and heavy equipment. However, even the operation at Crete showed the drawbacks of airborne assault. Many of the first wave of paratroops were killed either as they drifted defenselessly downward or immediately on landing as they disentangled themselves from their parachutes. More determined action by the British forces could have wiped them out. Success in Crete depended on aircraft also providing effective close air support and flying in fresh men and supplies to reinforce the initial attack.

Global conflict

By the end of 1941 the war had widened from a European conflict into a genuinely global struggle, with not only the Soviet Union but also the United States and Japan (already at war with China since 1937) entering the fray. There was a distinct difference in approaches to warfare on the two sides in the conflict. Germany, Italy, and

REICHSMARSCHAL GÖRING

Hitler invented the special title of Marshal of the Reich for his WWI ace Hermann Göring (front row, second from right) in the summer of 1940. But the morphine-addicted pilot later fell from favor as the Luftwaffe lost air superiority.

